



Let's try to lay out Sider's reasoning by isolating the various features of the **traditional doctrine** of heaven and hell that he thinks are inconsistent with the existence of a perfectly good God.

“A certain traditional conception of the afterlife is *binary*. After death one proceeds either to heaven or hell. Heaven is very, very good; hell is very, very bad. There are no possibilities for the afterlife other than heaven and hell, and membership in heaven or hell is never indeterminate or a matter of degree. The problem with the binary conception is that it contradicts God's justice. God must employ some criterion to decide who goes to heaven and who goes to hell. No reasonable criterion would be sharp; any reasonable criterion will have borderline cases. But the binary conception of the afterlife allows for no corresponding fuzziness in how the dead are to be treated. Hell must therefore contain people who are nearly indiscernible in relevant respects from people in Heaven. No just God would allow such a monstrously unfair thing.”

It is part of the traditional doctrine that God decides whether people go to heaven and hell based on certain properties of those people. We will leave open for now what those properties might be; just to have a name for them, let's call them the **relevant properties**.

Badness

Dichotomy

Non-  
universality

Divine  
control



Justice

# Proportion- ality

# Continuity

Let's turn to our second option. An easy way to resolve the problem would be to say that all people eventually go to heaven. (Or to hell — but the former option is more popular.) This view is called “universalism.”

This is the view of some Christian denominations. (To my knowledge it is not taught by any denominations of Islam.) Unitarians, for example, are typically universalists.

There is even some evidence that some early Church fathers thought of hell as temporary, and endorsed a kind of universalism.

Universalism certainly seems hard to reconcile with the teachings of most main monotheistic sects. Going further would mean verging into theology rather than philosophy, so I'll leave the discussion of this way out of the problem here, and turn to our next response.



the  
paradox of  
heaven and  
hell





replies to the  
paradox



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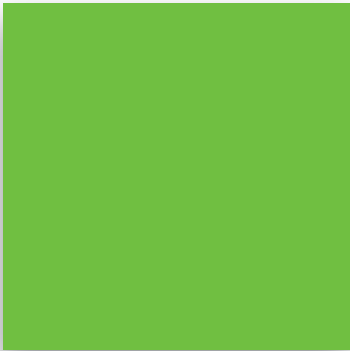
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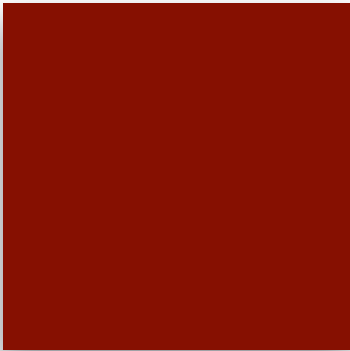














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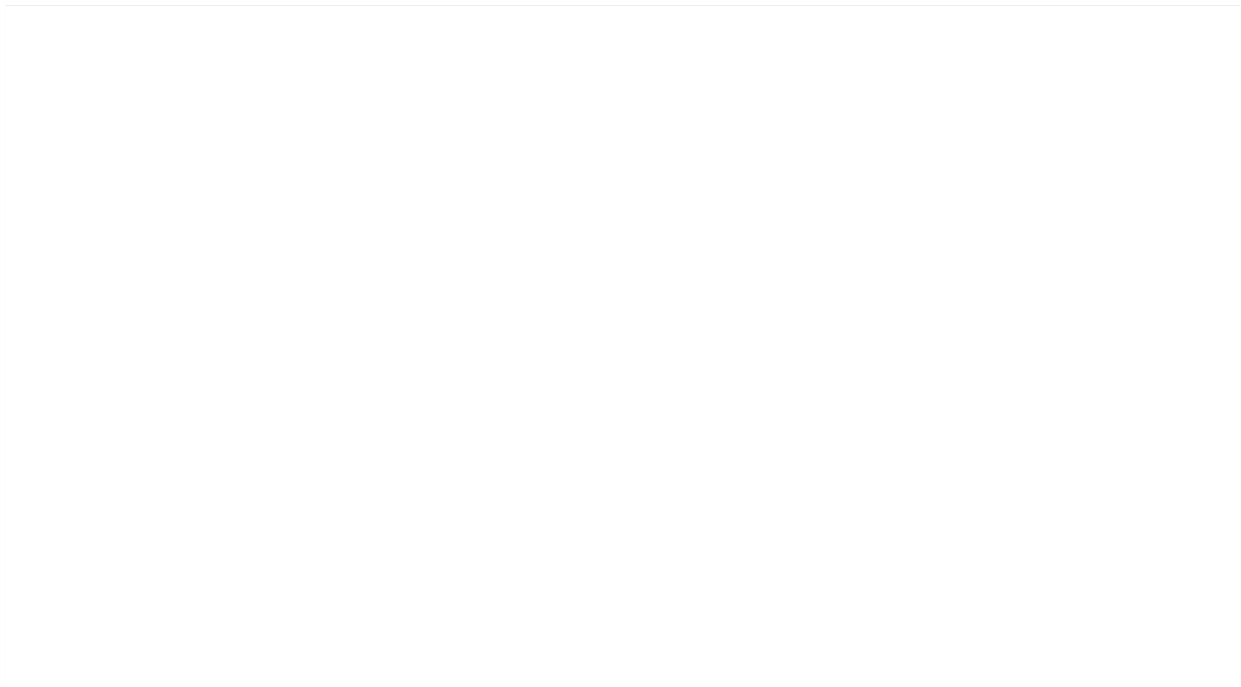
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The following passage from the Catechism of the Catholic Church

describes the kind of view wanted to discuss:





but the goats at the left.... and they will go away

all the nations, and he will separate them one from

just and the unjust,' will precede the Last

1038. The resurrection of all the dead, 'of both the

into external punishment, but the rights into

eternis in die !!

goats, and he will place the sheep at his right hand,



another as a shepherd separates the sheep from the

Judgment. Christ will come "in his glory, and all

the angels with him... Before him will be gathered

One topic often associated with belief in God is the topic of life after death.

many of the major monotheistic religions practiced with the existence of a

perfectly good Good?

Our first question today is: what we are told about life after death by





this glory, and all the angels with him.

1038. The reservation of the dead, "of

and the wild sheep are then from another

both the just and the unjust," will proceed

the Last Judgment. . . Christ will come "in

as a shepherd separates the sheep from the

goats, and the wild prairie sheep at his

Before him will be gathered all the nations,



they will go away into eternal punishment,

right hand, but the goat at the left... and

but the rights are all in it.

judgement on all of us, and on the basis of our life, decides that some of us will

This certainly seems like a picture according to which, after death, God passes

got to heaven forever, and some others to hell forever. (If not 'forever', then the

talk of the last judgment wouldn't make much sense.)

view of life after death we get here on pain of being perfectly good?



Turned-in showed why it is plausible that respo to the argument from evil

must depend on the possibility of life after death. We will now ask: is the kind of







































evil & lives  
not worth  
living



Badness



Non-  
universality

Divine  
control



Justice



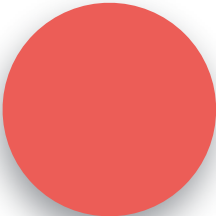
It seems difficult to deny Justice, Badness, or Divine Control. So that

seems to give the defender of the afterlife further main options.





replies to the  
paradox





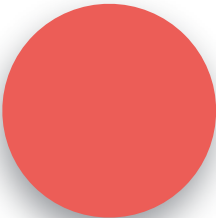








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